

GREAT IDEAS



GREAT MINDS

Public Will

IN INDIA, RELIGION IS NOT A PRIVATE BUSINESS. IF IT WERE, A WOMAN WALKING INTO THE SABARIMALA SHRINE WOULD NOT SHAKE THE FOUNDATIONS OF HINDUISM.

So let's ask that question again—should the state be completely divorced from religion? Answer number one: as we saw in France, a complete divorce is impossible. In order to maintain the separation, the state must continually define and engage with “the religious”. Answer number two: if it were possible, what does it mean to remove the external force while leaving the internal mechanisms intact? There would then be no outside to religious identity, no space to contest the tyrannies of communities. There has to be an outside into which religious dissenters can exit. In that case, should the state penetrate religion totally, reform all religions along the lines of constitutional values and citizenship rights? But how to trust the state which has its own vested interests against selected groups of citizens? People displaced by dams have no citizenship rights; nor do people who do not have sex the “natural” way. Besides, India is a democracy. So what people think matters, especially if those people invoke religion, and they certainly will if the state tries any such thing. Of course, they can be silenced. Both France and Turkey follow this strategy. But that's just



slamming the lid down tightly on a cauldron about to explode.

You see the problem. What we call religious identity today in India is constituted by state practices. Take away the state, and you have no religious identity. Religious beliefs, yes, identity



*Times change.
Aspirations don't.*